

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Adult hands-only CPR

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QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

If an adult suddenly collapses, is unresponsive and is not breathing normally or is only gasping, call emergency services, get an AED and start chest compressions. Push hard and fast in the center of the chest at 100–120 compressions per minute; follow dispatcher instructions.

Do now.

**Check safely**

01

Ensure the scene is safe and check responsiveness and breathing quickly.

**Call and get an AED**

02

Use speakerphone or send someone to call and bring an AED.

**Give compressions**

03

Place both hands in the center of the chest; compress at least 2 inches, avoiding more than 2.4 inches, and allow full recoil.

**Continue**

04

Follow the AED prompts and dispatcher instructions until responders take over or normal signs of life return.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

If a call will not connect, start or continue compressions. Ask another person to keep trying and bring an AED. If alone, use speakerphone while starting CPR rather than waiting for an answer. Do not leave an unresponsive person just to seek better reception.

Watch for.

This adult sudden-collapse guide does not replace infant or child CPR instructions. Gasping is not normal breathing.

People & practical needs.

Give someone the specific task of calling or locating care while another person provides first aid. Keep the patient warm or cool as the condition requires and record what happened and when. Do not put yourself into the same hazard or assume an ambulance has been dispatched until confirmed. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: check safely. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. This adult sudden-collapse guide does not replace infant or child CPR instructions. Gasping is not normal breathing.

Keep essentials within reach.

For adult hands-only cpr, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: If a call will not connect, start or continue compressions. Ask another person to keep trying and bring an AED. If alone, use speakerphone while starting CPR rather than waiting for an answer. Do not leave an unresponsive person just to seek better reception. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

Take a CPR course. Trained rescuers can give breaths according to training; children, infants, drowning and other breathing-related arrests need appropriate CPR with breaths.

First decision: Check safely

Ensure the scene is safe and check responsiveness and breathing quickly. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

If a call will not connect, start or continue compressions. Ask another person to keep trying and bring an AED. If alone, use speakerphone while starting CPR rather than waiting for an answer. Do not leave an unresponsive person just to seek better reception. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

This adult sudden-collapse guide does not replace infant or child CPR instructions. Gasping is not normal breathing. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

If an adult suddenly collapses, is unresponsive and is not breathing normally or is only gasping, call emergency services, get an AED and start chest compressions. Push hard and fast in the center of the chest at 100–120 compressions per minute; follow dispatcher instructions. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For adult hands-only cpr, keep the specific hazard in view: This adult sudden-collapse guide does not replace infant or child CPR instructions. Gasping is not normal breathing.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: Continue. Follow the AED prompts and dispatcher instructions until responders take over or normal signs of life return. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Adult hands-only CPR · official guidance

<https://www.redcross.org/take-a-class/cpr/performing-cpr/hands-only-cpr>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/cpr/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.